People and communities policies

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People Category

Policy framework

The AJP seeks to create a society where the welfare, and ability to thrive, of both humans and other animals is at the forefront, guided by compassion, inclusivity, just governance, and a commitment to sustainability. As responsible stewards for future generations we must consider the impact of our actions today on animals, the planet and by extension ourselves.

We acknowledge the intrinsic connection between humans and other animals, recognising the welfare of one directly impacts the other. When animals lead better lives, the result is not only reduced suffering and exploitation, but also an overall improvement in the health of our ecosystems, contributing to a healthier planet, and in turn, fostering healthier communities.

Practices such as factory farming and cruel treatment of animals not only raise moral and ethical questions but can also desensitise and harm individuals, and lead to environmental degradation creating further harm. We believe the wellbeing of people can be enhanced through ethical and compassionate choices in how we use, protect and interact with animals.

Te Tiriti o Waitangi holds profound significance for Aotearoa New Zealand, shaping the nation's foundation and fostering principles of justice, inclusivity, and cooperation.

The AJP embraces this treaty and acknowledges its importance in guiding a compassionate, just and equitable relationship with animals. The treaty's commitment to non-violent conflict resolution aligns with the AJP’s advocacy for compassionate conservation, emphasising ecological sustainability and social responsibility.

A just transition to a plant-based Aotearoa New Zealand reflects the essence of Te Tiriti o Waitangi, promoting harmony and respect for all beings within the nation's diverse tapestry.

The AJP is committed to improving the well-being of people by creating a better world for non-human animals.

The current economic system perpetuates harm to non-human animals whilst contributing to the exploitation and detriment of human well-being within these industries.

People employed in exploitative animal industries often endure hazardous working conditions, low wages and psychological distress due to the inherently violent nature of the work. Whilst equally people employed in organisations that care for and protect animals face burnout and compassion fatigue from constantly witnessing and responding to animal distress. The ongoing detrimental risks for humans include antibiotic resistance and the spread of zoonotic diseases.

We wish to address these interconnected issues to prioritise the advancement of both non-human animal wellbeing and human wellbeing.

We also advocate for increased nutritional knowledge and affordable access to a healthy diet and exercise opportunities for everyone.

We support a compassionate approach to all our interactions with each other, human or non-human animal.

People policies summary

The AJP believes that creating a better world for animals begins with building a more just, compassionate, and democratic society for all people. When humans are free from economic exploitation, can participate meaningfully in democratic processes, and are educated to value empathy and ethical decision-making, we create the conditions necessary for extending that same compassion to all sentient beings.

These policies address the interconnected systems that currently perpetuate harm to both humans and animals—from economic inequality that traps people in exploitative industries, to democratic deficits that allow wealthy interests to block necessary reforms, to educational systems that fail to nurture our natural capacity for compassion.

Honouring Te Tiriti o Waitangi forms the bedrock of our political platform. Grounded in kaitiakitanga (guardianship) and genuine partnership, our commitment to Te Tiriti shapes and informs each of the five core policy areas below.

1. Democratic Reform and Participation

Creating a democracy that truly serves all beings by ensuring every voice can be heard equally, regardless of wealth or political connections. These reforms will strengthen democratic processes, improve representation for marginal communities, and build the participatory systems needed to address complex challenges facing our society.

2. Worker Rights and Just Transition

Supporting people to transition away from industries that harm both workers and animals, while recognising the full humanity of all workers through comprehensive rights and support systems. These policies create pathways to meaningful, non-violent employment.

3. Economic Justice and Fairness

Building an economy that serves community wellbeing rather than enabling extreme wealth concentration and corporate manipulation of public opinion. These policies create ethical and legislative boundaries on wealth accumulation and corporate influence while supporting the transition to a more compassionate society.

4. Protection and Advocacy Rights

Protecting vulnerable people and animals from harm while safeguarding the democratic rights of those who speak up for others. These policies ensure that

exploitation and abuse cannot be hidden behind legal barriers, and that people can escape dangerous situations without abandoning the nonhuman animals they love.

5. Education and Community Building

Transforming education to nurture empathy, ethical awareness, and respect for all living beings from early childhood through to tertiary study. This foundation creates the next generation of citizens equipped with the compassion and critical thinking skills necessary for building a just society that values all sentient beings.

Strengthening Partnership with Tangata Whenua

The Animal Justice Party Aotearoa NZ (AJP) recognises that our history is both rich and at times turbulent. AJP accepts Te Tiriti o Waitangi as the founding document of Aotearoa, and commits to the principles of non-violent conflict resolution, compassionate conservation for ecological sustainability, social responsibility towards all of our peoples, and a just transition to a plant-based Aotearoa.

We believe in compassion, equality and non-violence therefore, we believe Māori and mātauranga Māori should be respected and embraced. While AJP predominantly focuses on animal rights and issues, we recognise Māori have an important role as kaitiakitanga (guardians) of the whenua (land), moana/awa/roto (seas/rivers/lakes) and kararehe (animals) of Aotearoa. To foster strong and respectful relationships between our party and the tangata whenua (people of the land) of Aotearoa, we are committed to upholding the rights of Māori to have a meaningful voice in decisions that directly impact them and their whenua (land). We recognise the importance of partnership and advocacy in ensuring that issues affecting Māori are addressed with fairness, inclusivity, and respect.

We acknowledge the role of Māori as tangata whenua (people of the land) and recognise the importance of kaitiakitanga, manaakitanga, and tino rangatiratanga in shaping a just transition. We understand that decolonisation is essential for creating the conditions where both Māori ways of being and environmental restoration can flourish, recognising that colonial structures have harmed both tangata whenua and the natural world they are connected to as kaitiaki.

Key Objective:

- Work towards establishing genuine partnerships with tangata whenua to create robust policies that will heal the environment and restore animal habitats whilst honouring mātauranga Māori.
- Support the establishment of strong kaitiakitanga frameworks to enable capabilities for Māori to protect kararehe, whenua, and moana/awa/roto through culturally appropriate conservation practices.
- Advocate for the protection efforts of tangata whenua in the use and care of natural resources, ensuring Māori have decision-making authority over ancestral lands and waters.
- Integrate mātauranga Māori into conservation science and animal welfare practices, recognising the value of indigenous knowledge systems in creating sustainable solutions.
- Restore degraded ecosystems through collaborative approaches that honour both scientific understanding and traditional ecological knowledge.

Addressing Colonial Impacts on Māori Health and Food Systems

The AJP recognises that colonisation and the establishment of intensive animal agriculture have created systemic injustices that continue to impact Māori health, land rights, and food sovereignty. We are committed to addressing these intersecting challenges through a just transition that honours Te Tiriti principles and supports Māori-led solutions.

The colonial transformation of Aotearoa into "the dairy farm of the British Empire" displaced traditional Māori food systems and imposed Western dietary patterns high in animal products, contributing to disproportionate health inequities that persist today. [1][2][3]Animal farming continues to degrade waterways[4] and ecosystems that are fundamental to Māori identity and wellbeing, with many Māori communities bearing the brunt of environmental pollution and land-use pressures.

We recognise that for many New Zealanders, including both Māori and Pākehā, there are strong cultural and historical ties to animal farming. For Māori, these ties are often rooted in whakapapa and a deep ancestral relationship with the land, while for Pākehā, the connection has developed more recently through settler-colonial history. Understanding these different histories is essential as we navigate a just transition away from animal-based systems.

AJP recognises that colonial systems have created structures of domination and exploitation that affect multiple communities and beings. We will support systemic changes that address these root causes whilst respecting the distinct nature of different liberation movements.

Key Objective:

- Ensure that Māori landholders are not disproportionately impacted by the transition away from animal agriculture and are supported in exercising kaitiakitanga, whilst prioritising Māori leadership in land-use decision-making to redress colonial injustices and support tino rangatiratanga.(*Transition to a Plant Based Economy policy objectives*)
- Support Māori food sovereignty through funding māra kai (community gardens), traditional food systems, and indigenous plant-based industries such as kūmara and native crops, recognising practices such as maramataka (Māori lunar planting cycles) as integral to sustainable food production. (*Transition to a Plant Based Economy policy objectives*)

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[1] Public Health Advisory Committee. 2024. Rebalancing our food system. Wellington: Ministry of Health.
[2] Cleghorn C, Nghiem N, Ni Mhurchu C. Assessing the Health and Environmental Benefits of a New Zealand Diet Optimised for Health and Climate Protection. Sustainability. 2022; 14(21):13900. https://doi.org/10.3390/su142113900
[3] https://thespinoff.co.nz/kai/31-07-2024/around-the-world-food-insecurity-is-improving-in-new-zealand-its-getting-worse
[4] See: MfE (2020): https://environment.govt.nz/publications/our-freshwater-2020/

- Create specific economic pathways for Māori landowners, including iwi with returned Crown forestry land, to gain benefits from environmentally beneficial land uses that align with kaitiakitanga principles, supported by a Māori Alternative Proteins Advisory Board and Innovation Fund. (*Transition to a Plant Based Economy policy objectives*)
- Ensure that food assistance programmes and the National Food Strategy are developed in partnership with iwi and hapū to address health inequities and food access issues that disproportionately affect Māori communities. (*Transition to a Plant Based Economy policy objectives*)

1. Democratic Reform and Participation

Getting Money Out of Politics - Restoring Democratic Equality

The AJP is committed to creating a democracy where all voices are heard equally, regardless of wealth or corporate connections. We acknowledge that money currently dominates our political system, giving wealthy industries—particularly those that exploit animals—vastly superior access to decision-makers compared to ordinary citizens and community advocates. We propose comprehensive reforms to eliminate financial advantages in politics, ensuring democratic participation is based on ideas and community support rather than economic power.

Unregulated lobbying creates a two-tier democracy where wealthy interests dominate decision-making while ordinary citizens and advocacy groups are shut out. The revelations in August 2025 about the then Fisheries Minister Shane Jones receiving over $100,000 from fishing industry donors while rolling back environmental protections illustrate this problem perfectly.[5] Companies like Talley's Group strategically split donations to avoid disclosure thresholds, while fishing baron Craig Boote admitted to spending $30,000 across parties before securing exclusive access to ministers.[6] This isn't democracy - it's a system where money buys policy outcomes.

Although Federated Farmers does not make direct political donations,[7] influence can flow through other channels. Andrew Hoggard's career path illustrates the concern: after nearly a decade in Federated Farmers leadership roles, including serving as president until May 2023, he joined ACT New Zealand the very next day.[8] Following the 2023 election, he was appointed Minister for Biosecurity and Food Safety, and Associate Minister of Agriculture (Animal Welfare, Skills)[9] and for the Environment, portfolios directly affecting farming and animal welfare. This revolving door between industry leadership and political office underlines the urgent need for reform: mandatory lobbying registers, cooling-off periods, and stronger transparency rules to ensure that public decision-making serves the wider public interest.

The connection to animal welfare is direct and profound. Industries that exploit animals (factory farming, commercial fishing, entertainment using animals) rely heavily on political influence to maintain harmful practices. By eliminating their

[5] https://theintegrityinstitute.substack.com/p/integrity-briefing-fishy-influence
[6] https://theintegrityinstitute.substack.com/p/integrity-briefing-fishy-influence
[7] https://theintegrityinstitute.substack.com/p/federated-farmers
[8] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Andrew_Hoggard
[9] https://www.beehive.govt.nz/minister/biography/andrew-hoggard

financial advantages, we create space for evidence-based policy that considers animal welfare alongside human and environmental concerns.

When wealth can't buy political influence, policy debates focus on ideas, evidence, and community values rather than corporate interests. This creates conditions where animal welfare advocates can participate on equal terms with industry representatives, leading to policies that reflect genuine public concern for animals rather than industry profit margins.

The AJP believes that getting money out of politics is a fundamental step that can be taken now to restore democratic equality and ensure all voices are heard. It will create policy-making processes that serve community wellbeing rather than corporate profits, reduce the political power of industries that exploit animals, and establish the democratic foundations necessary for building a compassionate society where the interests of all beings are properly considered.

Key Objectives:

Transparency & Electoral Finance

1. Limit total donations and loans from any single individual to a maximum of $30,000 per electoral cycle (or $10,000 per year) to curb excessive influence.
2. Reduce the threshold for publicly disclosing a donor's identity from $5,000 to $1,500 per year, preventing the "splitting" of donations.
3. Permit only New Zealand citizens or permanent residents registered to vote to make political donations, removing corporate/industry "entity" donations.
4. Remove the mechanism that allows large donations to be funneled anonymously through the Electoral Commission.

Lobbying & Institutional Integrity

5. Implement comprehensive lobbying transparency with real-time public disclosure of all meetings and communications between industry representatives and government officials
6. Create meaningful cooling-off periods preventing the revolving door between industry leadership and political positions
7. Establish independent oversight with strong enforcement powers to investigate breaches and maintain democratic integrity
8. Protect public interest advocacy organisations from government retaliation while ensuring equal access to democratic processes

Democratic Participation & Campaign Equality

9. Establish maximum membership fee caps for all political parties with low-income options, preventing wealthy parties from creating financial barriers while ensuring participation is based on community support rather than wealth
10. Level broadcasting allocation between parties, distributing funding more evenly rather than concentrating it among established parties, and expand eligible spending to include TV, radio, digital ads, leaflets, print materials, direct mail, accessibility services, community media partnerships, shared infrastructure and small-party participation in debates
11. Require at least 50% of public campaign funding to be spent with New Zealand businesses rather than overseas platforms
12. Create infrastructure for small-party participation in televised and public debates.

Democratic Representation for All Voices

The AJP is committed to reducing the MMP party vote threshold from 5% to 3.5% to ensure that diverse voices, including those advocating for animals, environment, and social justice, can meaningfully participate in parliamentary democracy.[10] We acknowledge that the current 5% threshold excludes significant portions of the population from representation, particularly those supporting smaller parties focused on ethical issues that major parties often ignore or compromise on.

An independent review of New Zealand's electoral system has concluded a major shake-up of MMP is needed to ensure a fairer and more accessible democracy. The current threshold means that parties receiving up to 4.9% of the vote—potentially representing over 120,000 voters—receive no parliamentary representation whatsoever. This creates a democratic deficit where substantial communities advocating for animal protection, environmental justice, and other ethical concerns are systematically excluded from decision-making processes.

International comparisons reveal New Zealand's threshold is unnecessarily high. In Bolivia the threshold is 3%, in Germany 5% for federal parliament, while some European nations operate effectively with thresholds as low as 2%. The Electoral Commission recommended lowering the 5 percent party vote threshold to 3.5 percent as part of comprehensive electoral reforms designed to enhance democratic participation.[11]

Reducing the threshold would enable parties focused on animal welfare, environmental protection, and social justice to gain parliamentary representation with community support levels that already demonstrate significant public backing. This change would force major parties to engage seriously with ethical issues they currently marginalise, knowing that specialist parties could hold balance-of-power positions.

The AJP believes that lowering the party vote threshold is a fundamental democratic reform that will amplify voices advocating for those without political power—including animals. This change will ensure that ethical concerns receive proper parliamentary consideration, create more responsive governance, and build the inclusive democracy necessary for addressing complex challenges facing all beings in our society.

Key Objectives:

[10] Setting the electoral threshold | RNZ

[11] https://s3.ap-southeast-2.amazonaws.com/nzdoctor.files/production/public/2024-01/Independent-Electoral-Review-Final-Report-November-2023.pdf

1. Advocate for legislation reducing the MMP party vote threshold from 5% to 3.5% in line with Electoral Commission recommendations
2. Campaign for broader electoral reforms that enhance democratic participation and representation of diverse viewpoints
3. Support constitutional changes that recognise the rights of future generations and non-human beings in democratic processes
4. Promote electoral education programmes that help communities understand how threshold changes affect representation

Participatory Democracy for Complex Societal Issues

The AJP is committed to creating a democracy that truly serves all beings by ensuring citizens can meaningfully participate in complex decision-making processes. We acknowledge that current democratic systems often fail to address challenging issues due to polarisation, partisan politics, and the dominance of vested interests over genuine public deliberation. We propose strengthening participatory democracy to build the foundations of a more thoughtful, inclusive, and compassionate society.

Participatory democracy goes beyond traditional voting by involving citizens directly in decision-making on complex issues. It includes methods like citizens' assemblies, where randomly selected groups of people learn about an issue, hear from experts, and deliberate together to make recommendations.

Ireland's Citizens' Assembly on abortion provides a powerful example.[12] In 2016, 99 randomly selected citizens spent five months examining this issue, hearing from medical experts, legal scholars and people with lived experiences. Their thoughtful recommendations led to a referendum that legalised abortion - a result many thought impossible through traditional politics alone.

Research shows deliberative democracy works. An OECD study of citizens' assemblies found that over half of the recommendations were implemented by public authorities in 76% of cases reviewed, and all recommendations implemented in 36% of cases.[13] In Aotearoa New Zealand, we already have 15+ examples of successful deliberative democracy at local level, proving our communities are ready for this approach.[14]

The AJP believes that empowering citizens to engage deeply with complex ethical questions is an effective step that can be taken now to build a more compassionate democracy. It will lead to better policy outcomes that consider the interests of all affected beings, break through political polarisation and create the democratic culture necessary for addressing the greatest challenges facing our society and planet.

Key Objectives:

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[12] https://www.democracy.community/stories/irish-referendum-abortion-feat-direct-democracy
[13] OECD (2020), Innovative Citizen Participation and New Democratic Institutions: Catching the Deliberative Wave, OECD Publishing, Paris, https://doi.org/10.1787/339306da-en.
[14] Simon Wright, Tatjana Buklijas, and Max Rashbrooke, “The Rise, Fall and Re-Rise of Deliberative Democracy in New Zealand,” Policy Quarterly 20, no. 2 (May 2024): 3–11, https://doi.org/10.26686/pq.v20i2.9478.

1. Establish citizens' assemblies for major policy decisions currently deadlocked by political partisanship
2. Support local councils in implementing deliberative democracy practices for community planning decisions
3. Create comprehensive training programmes for public servants in facilitating participatory processes
4. Fund community organisations to participate meaningfully in democratic processes
5. Develop digital platforms to enable broader community participation in policy development
6. Introduce deliberative polling on complex social issues to inform government decision-making

Comprehensive Wellbeing Data Framework

The AJP is committed to creating evidence-based governance that measures what truly matters for thriving communities. We acknowledge that current data systems focus primarily on economic indicators while ignoring social, environmental and ethical dimensions of wellbeing, making it impossible to track whether our policies actually improve lives for all beings. We propose establishing comprehensive wellbeing data systems that capture the full spectrum of what makes communities healthy and compassionate.

You can't improve what you don't measure. While New Zealand still has wellbeing tools like the Living Standards Framework (including the LSF Dashboard)[15] and the He Ara Waiora framework,[16] recent changes, such as removal of certain wellbeing requirements in the Public Finance Act and the discontinuation of the branded Wellbeing Budget[17][18] have weakened mandatory reporting and accountability. This leaves gaps in our ability to track whether policies are improving people's lives or to identify where interventions could have the greatest impact.

A proposal for a comprehensive wellbeing data system is not without precedent. The Kingdom of Bhutan, for instance, pioneered the concept of Gross National Happiness (GNH), which deliberately elevated the wellbeing of its citizens above Gross Domestic Product (GDP) as its central development philosophy. The resulting GNH Index is a robust, multidimensional measurement tool that guides policymaking across nine domains, including ecological resilience, cultural vitality and time use.[19] This international example of embedding social, environmental and ethical dimensions into a mandated policy-screening framework demonstrates a successful model for the "compassionate governance" and full-spectrum measurement we are committed to achieving in New Zealand.

The AJP believes that implementing comprehensive wellbeing data is an effective step that can be taken now to build accountability for compassionate governance. It will lead to better policy decisions that consider the interconnectedness of human, animal, and environmental health, provide clear evidence of what interventions work best and create the foundation for a society that values the wellbeing of all beings.

Key Objectives:

1. Review existing wellbeing indicators from other jurisdictions and national datasets to identify best practice methodologies

[15] Our Living Standards Framework | The Treasury New Zealand
[16] He Ara Waiora | The Treasury New Zealand
[17] https://www.treasury.govt.nz/publications/wellbeing-budget/wellbeing-budget-2022-secure-future
[18] New Zealand – Implementing the Wellbeing Budget
[19] GNH HAPPINESS INDEX

2. Gather new wellbeing data through community collaboration, combining statistical data with qualitative community insights
3. Mandate inclusion of animal welfare and environmental stewardship indicators in all wellbeing frameworks
4. Resource community organisations to participate meaningfully in data gathering and interpretation processes
5. Establish regular community wellbeing surveys that include questions about people's relationship with animals and nature
6. Create publicly accessible dashboards showing progress on wellbeing indicators at local and national levels

2. Worker Rights and Just Transition

Mental Health Support and Just Transition for Workers in Violent / Exploitative Industries

The AJP is committed to creating a society where no person is forced into work that causes psychological harm to themselves and violence to others. We recognise that many industries founded on systematic harm, including, but not limited to, animal exploitation (slaughterhouses, factory farming), industrial wildlife harvesting, and other violent production systems, impose deep psychological burdens on workers. These burdens often extend into families and communities, creating cycles of trauma that affect both humans and non-humans.

We propose comprehensive mental health support and retraining programmes to help workers transition away from these harmful industries towards meaningful, non-violent employment.

While slaughterhouse work is among the most extreme cases, because of the nature of killing and dismemberment, workers in industrial farming (e.g. intensive confinement, culling, animal handling), pest control, fur or wildlife harvest industries may face analogous harms and deserve equal attention in this policy.[20]

Recent research on farmer wellbeing highlights similar moral and psychological strain within intensive animal agriculture, describing how livestock farmers experience *moral distress* and *moral injury* arising from repeated exposure to animal suffering and killing, contributing to elevated rates of mental ill-health.[21] [22]This underscores the need for trauma-informed support across all animal-use sectors, not only in slaughterhouses.

Research consistently demonstrates the severe psychological toll of slaughterhouse employment. A systematic literature review found that slaughterhouse workers exhibit higher prevalence of depression, anxiety, and other psychological distress, as well as a tendency toward violence-supportive attitudes relative to general

[20] Scott-Reid, J. (2024). How good people do bad things to animals. https://sentientmedia.org/good-people-bad-things-animals/
[21] Bryant research (2025). The Hidden Toll of Slaughter on Farmers' Mental Health. https://bryantresearch.co.uk/insight-items/farmer-mental-health/
[22] https://bitesizevegan.org/ptsd-in-slaughterhouse-workers/

populations.[23] In industrial US settings, Leibler et al. found elevated rates of serious psychological distress among slaughterhouse employees.[24]

Research indicates that repeated exposure to animal killing can produce trauma-related symptoms, including emotional numbing, guilt, and disconnection, effects resembling those seen in post-traumatic stress.[25] [26]

Beyond individual harm, community impacts have been observed. In a longitudinal study of 581 nonmetropolitan U.S. counties (1994-2002) found that increases in slaughterhouse employment were correlated with rises in total arrests, violent crime arrests, rape, and other sex offense arrests (versus counties without or with smaller slaughterhouse employment levels).[27] In one documented town, a reported 70 % increase in crime followed slaughterhouse expansion (though that figure comes from qualitative/historical accounts cited within the study's context).[28]

In Aotearoa New Zealand, the scale of this industry is substantial:

- ~145,349 people: This figure represents the estimated employment for the broad Agriculture, Forestry, and Fishing (ANZSIC Level 1) sector in New Zealand,[29] including:
    - Over 25,000 workers in meat processing across 60 locations nationally[30]
    - 3,500 people employed in the poultry industry[31]

These workers process in 2023, figures included 5.9 million dairy cattle, 3.7 million beef cattle, 24.4 million sheep and 740,000 deer[32] and the slaughter of over 124 million chickens, 591,000 pigs, 357,000 ducks and 238,000 turkeys.[33] Yet the psychological cost to these workers and their communities remains unaddressed.

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[23] Slade, G., Alleyne, E., & Dixon, L. (2022). *The psychological impact of slaughterhouse employment: A systematic literature review.* **Traumatology, 28**(2), 231–241. https://doi.org/10.1037/trm0000325

[24] Leibler J. H., Janulewicz P. A., Perry M. J.(2017). Prevalence of serious psychological distress among industrial US slaughterhouse workers https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/full/10.3233/WOR-172543

[25] Dillard, J. (2008). *A slaughterhouse nightmare: Psychological harm suffered by slaughterhouse employees and the possibility of redress through legal reform.* **Georgetown Journal on Poverty Law & Policy, 15**, 391–408.

[26] https://theconversation.com/animals-suffer-for-meat-production-and-abattoir-workers-do-too-127506

[27] https://www.researchgate.net/publication/249701326_Slaughterhouses_and_Increased_Crime_Rates_An_Empirical_Analysis_of_the_Spillover_From_The_Jungle_Into_the_Surrounding_Community

[28] ibid

[29] https://rep.infometrics.co.nz/new-zealand/employment/structure

[30] https://mia.co.nz/about-mia/ Retrieved 14 October 2025

[31] https://www.pianz.org.nz/nz-chicken/#nz-chicken-section-2 Retrieved 14 October 2025

[32] https://www.stats.govt.nz/indicators/livestock-numbers-data-to-2023/

[33] https://ourworldindata.org/grapher/animals-slaughtered-for-meat?country=~NZL

Comprehensive Support Framework:

Immediate Mental Health Interventions:

- Free counselling and psychological support services
- Trauma-informed therapy specifically addressing work-related PTSD
- Support groups connecting workers with others making the transition
- Family counselling to address domestic violence and relationship issues stemming from work trauma

Skills Development and Retraining:

- Funded apprenticeships in plant-based food production and processing
- Training programmes for environmental restoration, sustainable agriculture, and renewable energy sectors
- Business development support for workers wanting to start plant-based food enterprises
- Recognition of prior learning to credit relevant experience towards new qualifications

Economic Transition Support:

- Income support during retraining periods to ensure workers can leave harmful employment without financial hardship
- Relocation assistance for workers in remote areas dependent on single violent production systems
- Preferential hiring programmes with companies committed to employing former workers from violent production systems

Community Healing:

- Community development programmes in violent production systems-dependent towns to address elevated crime and social problems
- Support for alternative economic development that doesn't rely on animal exploitation
- Investment in mental health services and violence prevention programmes in affected communities

This policy reflects our core values of non-violence, equality, and just transition. Research shows workers often resort to maladaptive coping mechanisms including emotional detachment, self-medication with drugs and alcohol, and in some cases aggressive or violent behaviour, with documented psychosocial consequences such as domestic violence and community level crime. By addressing these harms, we

protect both the workers and the families and animals who suffer from the spillover effects of this violence.[34]

The AJP believes that supporting workers within violent production systems to transition to non-violent employment is a crucial step that can be taken now to break cycles of trauma and violence. It will lead to improved mental health outcomes for workers and their families, reduced crime rates in affected communities, and create the skilled workforce needed for our transition to a compassionate, plant-based economy that values the wellbeing of all beings.

Key Objectives:

1. Establish dedicated mental health services specifically designed for workers within violent production systems, including trauma-informed care and PTSD treatment programmes
2. Create comprehensive retraining and transition support packages enabling workers to develop skills for non-violent industries such as plant-based food production, renewable energy, and environmental restoration
3. Implement community support programmes in areas with high concentrations of violent production systems work to address elevated crime rates and social problems
4. Provide financial support during transition periods, ensuring workers aren't trapped in harmful employment due to economic necessity

[34] Dillard, J. (2008). *A slaughterhouse nightmare: Psychological harm suffered by slaughterhouse employees and the possibility of redress through legal reform.* **Georgetown Journal on Poverty Law & Policy, 15**, 391–408.

Ethical Procurement and Fair Employment

The AJP is committed to transforming government procurement practices to support local businesses, fair wages, and ethical supply chains that prioritise community wellbeing over profit maximisation. We acknowledge that government spending currently fails to leverage its significant purchasing power to create positive social and environmental outcomes, often inadvertently supporting industries that exploit both workers and animals.

By harnessing the purchasing power of public institutions, we can create economic pathways for workers transitioning from exploitative industries—including factory farming and other animal-based industries—whilst supporting businesses that embody values of compassion and sustainability. Government procurement represents billions of dollars annually that can either perpetuate harmful systems or actively build a more ethical economy.

When businesses know that government contracts require fair wages and ethical practices, they adapt their operations accordingly. This creates market incentives that extend far beyond government spending, influencing entire supply chains. The Māori economy already demonstrates leadership in values-based business practices, with many Māori enterprises naturally embodying care for environment and future generations, [35]principles that align perfectly with compassionate treatment of all beings.

The AJP believes that ethical procurement is an effective tool that can be implemented now to support workers, animals, and communities. It will accelerate the transition to a more compassionate economy, strengthen local businesses that prioritise ethics over exploitation, and create the economic conditions necessary for building a society where both humans and animals can thrive.

Key Objectives:

1. Mandate all government suppliers pay living wages to create economic pathways for workers transitioning from exploitative animal industries
2. Prioritise procurement from local businesses that demonstrate environmental responsibility and ethical treatment of animals
3. Strengthen Māori business participation in government contracts, recognising tikanga values that naturally align with caring for all beings
4. Establish supplier certification programmes that reward businesses prioritising people, planet, and animals over profit margins

[35] Ministry of Business, Innovation and Employment. (2025). *Te Ōhanga Māori – The Māori Economy 2023 report*. https://www.mbie.govt.nz/assets/te-ohanga-maori-2023-report.pdf Retrieved 14 october 2025.

Companion Animal Bereavement and Parental Leave

The AJP is committed to recognising the profound emotional bonds between humans and companion animals, acknowledging that these relationships provide immense psychological, emotional and social benefits that mirror many aspects of human family connections. We acknowledge that current employment law fails to recognise the grief and care needs associated with companion animals, forcing people to use sick leave or holiday entitlement during some of their most vulnerable moments.

We propose establishing statutory rights to bereavement and parental leave for companion animal guardians. Leave entitlements should be flexible blocks that employees can use to care for who they consider family, whether parents, children, or companion animals. This approach avoids additional administrative burden for businesses while reflecting the reality of modern family life.

Half of pet owners say their animal is a member of the family, equal to humans, reflecting the deep emotional connections that have developed over thousands of years of co-evolution. Anyone who has ever loved a pet knows: they're not "just animals" - they're family. They're the wagging tail that greets us after a hard day, the purring companion during late-night work sessions, and the loyal friend who never judges our worst moments.

Some forward-thinking employers have already recognised this reality. Google, Starbucks, United Airlines and Walmart have embraced a so-called "pet-conscious workplace",[36] while pet ownership surged during the pandemic,[37] and more workplaces have become pet-friendly.[38] The concept of "pawternity leave", time off (paid or unpaid) for staff who have recently brought home a pet, is gaining recognition internationally.[39]

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[36] Martínez, A., & Fadel, L. (2024, April 29). *Should people get bereavement leave for the death of a pet?* Texas Public Radio. https://www.tpr.org/2024-04-29/should-people-get-bereavement-leave-for-the-death-of-a-pet

[37] Animal Medicines Australia. (2021). *Pets and the pandemic: A social research snapshot of pets and people in the COVID-19 era* https://animalmedicinesaustralia.org.au/resources/pets-and-the-pandemic-a-social-research-snapshot-of-pets-and-people-in-the-covid-19-era/

[38] Roff, E. M., & Hinchliffe, K. (2024). Dog-friendly workplaces: Understanding what works and lessons learned through reflexive thematic analysis. *Personnel Assessment and Decisions*, *10*(1), 1-22. https://docs.lib.purdue.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1160&context=paij

[39] Chandler, V. (2016, May 16). Companies are now offering Pawternity leave to new pet owners. *Good Housekeeping*. https://www.goodhousekeeping.com/uk/news/a561203/pawternity-leave-new-pets/

Currently, pet leave isn't a legal right, but some businesses offer it.[40] This creates inequality where workers in progressive companies receive support while others must navigate grief and companion animal care using inappropriate leave categories or risk job security. The absence of statutory rights means many people cannot properly grieve the loss of beloved companions or adequately care for newly adopted animals during critical bonding periods.

Policy Framework

- **Bereavement Leave**
    - Up to 5 days paid leave available as a single entitlement for use following the death of a close human family member *or* a companion animal.
    - Flexible timing to cover funerals, tangihanga, memorials, veterinary appointments, or grieving.
    - Self-declaration only—no burdensome paperwork.
- **Parental ("Pawternity") Leave**
    - Up to 3 days paid leave available when a new family member joins the household, whether a baby or an adopted companion animal.
    - Additional unpaid leave (up to 2 weeks) available for animals with special needs or trauma histories.
- **Emergency Care Leave**
    - Employees may take reasonable time off to respond to urgent medical emergencies, end-of-life decision-making, or intensive care needs—for human or animal family members.

This policy reflects our core belief that recognising the sentience and emotional value of animals creates a more compassionate society overall. When we acknowledge the grief people feel for companion animals, we validate the emotional lives of those animals and reinforce that all beings deserve consideration and respect.

The AJP believes that establishing companion animal bereavement and parental leave is a compassionate step that can be taken now to support the millions of New Zealanders who share their lives with animal family members. This policy will reduce workplace stress, improve employee wellbeing, and strengthen a compassionate culture in Aotearoa New Zealand.

Key Objectives:

[40] World Animal Protection NZ. (n.d.). *Work with us*. Retrieved October 14, 2025, from https://www.worldanimalprotection.org.nz/about-us/work-with-us/

1. Establish statutory bereavement leave (up to 5 days) for family members, human or nonhuman animals
2. Create "pawternity leave" entitlement of up to 3 days for new family members, including companion animals
3. Extend emergency leave provisions to cover urgent care for both human and nonhuman family
4. Ensure leave entitlements apply equally to all recognised forms of family life

Making Work Fair for All

The AJP is committed to rebuilding worker rights in Aotearoa New Zealand, recognising that exploitative employment conditions not only harm workers but create the economic desperation that drives animal exploitation industries. Decades of neoliberal policies have systematically weakened collective bargaining, suppressed wages and created precarious employment conditions that trap workers in harmful industries while undermining their capacity to make ethical choices. We acknowledge that strong worker rights are fundamental to a just society for all beings, enabling fair distribution of economic gains while ensuring workers have genuine voice in transitioning away from industries that exploit animals. We propose comprehensive labour law reform that puts workers' collective power at the centre of employment relations and supports the transition to a compassionate economy.

Worker empowerment through collective organisation is essential for creating an economy that serves all beings rather than concentrating wealth among employers and shareholders who profit from animal exploitation. Strong unions and worker rights provide the foundation for reducing inequality, improving workplace safety, and enabling workers to transition away from industries that harm animals without facing economic destitution. When workers have economic security and collective power, they are better positioned to resist participating in animal exploitation and to advocate for ethical alternatives. Improving work-life balance while maintaining productivity and enabling workers to participate more fully in community life enables ethical consumption choices and the reduction in animal exploitation.

Many of the most harmful animal exploitation industries - from factory farming to animal testing - rely on precarious employment conditions that trap workers in jobs they may find morally troubling. Economic desperation forces workers to participate in systems of animal cruelty, while weak labour protections prevent them from speaking out about animal welfare violations they witness. The AJP will establish just transition support for workers moving from animal exploitation industries to compassionate alternatives, including retraining programmes, income support during transition periods, and priority hiring in emerging plant-based and cruelty-free industries.

The AJP believes that restoring worker rights through comprehensive employment law reform is essential for creating a society where workers can choose compassionate careers without sacrificing their economic security. This approach will reduce inequality, strengthen democracy in workplaces, and create the economic foundations for a society that values the wellbeing of all beings over profit maximisation from animal exploitation.

Key Objectives:

1. Strengthen and expand the *Employment Relations Act 2000* with a comprehensive Charter of Workers' Rights
2. Establish maximum pay ratios of 10:1 for all private and public sector organisations
3. Increase the minimum wage to $25 per hour regardless of age
4. Guarantee equal employment rights for all workers from their first day of employment, including those in the gig economy and on zero-hours contracts
5. Transition to a four-day working week as the standard full-time arrangement
6. Establish just transition support for workers moving from animal exploitation industries

3. Economic Justice and Fairness

Ethical Advertising Standards - Protecting Communities from Harmful Marketing

The AJP is committed to creating advertising standards that serve community wellbeing, rather than corporate profits, recognising that current marketing practices actively undermine efforts to build a compassionate society. We acknowledge that advertising for harmful products, particularly animal products, fossil fuels, and excessive consumption, manipulates people into choices that damage their health, exploit animals, and destroy our environment. We propose phased restrictions on harmful advertising, starting with the most damaging sectors and moving towards an advertising landscape that informs rather than exploits.

Modern advertising is fundamentally about manufacturing desires for things we don't need, often at tremendous cost to animals, people, and planet. The industry spends billions convincing people that happiness comes from consuming animal products, burning fossil fuels, and buying endless goods, directly contradicting the urgent need to reduce harm and consumption for a sustainable future.

Children are particularly vulnerable, with food marketing creating lifelong preferences for processed animal products while normalising cruelty as entertainment. By the time a child reaches school age, they've been exposed to thousands of advertisements promoting consumption patterns that cause immense animal suffering and environmental destruction.

France has led globally by banning fossil fuel advertising since 2022,[41] while Amsterdam became the first city to ban meat and dairy advertising on public transport in 2024.[42] These pioneering approaches demonstrate that restricting harmful advertising is both achievable and effective in shifting social norms towards sustainability and compassion.

The connection to animal welfare is direct and profound. Animal product advertising deliberately obscures the reality of factory farming, presenting false images of happy animals while promoting products that cause immense suffering. By restricting this misleading marketing, we create space for honest conversations about our food choices and their impact on sentient beings.

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[41] Reclame Fossielvrij. (2022, August 22). *Overview worldwide initiatives to ban fossil fuel ads*. World Without Fossil Ads. Retrieved October 24, 2025, from https://verbiedfossielereclame.nl/only-words/

[42] Plant Based Treaty. (2025, March 28). *Nijmegen endorses Plant Based Treaty and bans meat advertisements*. Retrieved October 24, 2025, from https://plantbasedtreaty.org/nijmegen/

This policy also addresses the economic pressures that trap people in harmful consumption patterns.[43] Pervasive advertising for expensive, environmentally destructive products fuels a "work-and-spend" cycle that cultivates financial dependence and status anxiety. This pressure often compels individuals to remain in or seek alienating or exploitative employment, including jobs in animal agriculture and other harmful industries, to maintain a high-consumption lifestyle.[44] [45]

The AJP believes that restricting harmful advertising is a practical step that can be taken now to reduce manipulation of public opinion and create space for genuine community conversations about our choices. It will reduce the cultural pressure to consume products that harm animals, decrease the economic power of exploitative industries, and create conditions where people can make informed decisions based on their values rather than corporate manipulation.[46]

Key Objectives:

1. Implement immediate bans on advertising for factory-farmed animal products, fossil fuels, and excessive consumption to reduce normalisation of harmful practices

2. Establish information-based advertising standards that require factual disclosure of environmental and ethical impacts rather than emotional manipulation

3. Protect children from all commercial advertising, creating space for education about compassionate choices free from corporate influence

4. Support ethical businesses and cooperatives with reduced regulations and public funding for marketing plant-based and sustainable alternatives

5. Transform public spaces from corporate advertising zones into community-controlled areas that promote wellbeing rather than consumption

6. Create strong enforcement mechanisms with revenue-based penalties ensuring large corporations cannot ignore advertising restrictions

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[43] DeSmog. (2022). *Words vs. actions: The truth behind the advertising of the car and airline industries* (Report commissioned by Greenpeace Netherlands). Greenpeace. https://www.greenpeace.org/static/planet4-netherlands-stateless/2022/05/778192bc-greenpeace_wordsvsactions_carair.pdf

[44] Schor, J. B. (1991). *The overworked American: The unexpected decline of leisure*. Basic Books.

[45] Kasser, T. (2002). *The high price of materialism*. MIT Press.

[46] McNeill, S. (2023, May 30). Australia's crackdown on climate activists Human Rights Watch. https://www.hrw.org/news/2023/05/30/australias-crackdown-climate-activists

Non-discrimination against tenants and companion animals

The Animal Justice Party of Aotearoa New Zealand (AJP) wishes to address the issue of discrimination against tenants with companion animals in the private rental and social housing market. We support the supply of fair and inclusive housing, while acknowledging the significant responsibility one has as a companion animal guardian.

AJP believes that, by fostering a sense of community while promoting responsible companion animal care, we can support both landlords and renters to have equitable access to the many documented social and health benefits of companion animal guardianship.

AJP advocates for an end to discrimination against tenants with companion animals. Eliminating this discrimination would help address one of the significant barriers to tenants sourcing suitable accommodation with their companion animals. By implementing this policy, a more inclusive and compassionate rental housing market in Aotearoa can be established.

Key Objectives:

1. Reform rental housing laws to ensure companion animals' rights and prevent discrimination against companion animals and their guardians.
2. Work with insurance providers to ensure comprehensive coverage for landlords and tenants.
3. Eliminate additional bond requirements for companion animal guardians in private rental properties and social housing.
4. Encourage responsible guardianship by developing and investing in educational campaigns promoting responsible guardianship and property care.
5. Implement clear processes for landlords to follow if they feel tenants are not acting responsibly as guardians of companion animals.
6. Introduce and support a Companion Animal Guardianship clause such as, establishing a certification program, which provides a "Seal of Approval"
7. Support companion animal friendly housing initiatives by encouraging and investing in the development of companion animal friendly rental options nationwide, including tenants in intensive housing, interim housing and animal friendly rest homes.
8. Repeal the “no cause” termination and reinstate protections against arbitrary evictions.

Background

Aotearoa New Zealand has the second largest proportion of homes with companion animals[47]. It is clear that companion animals are a huge part of our society and as such we have a responsibility to ensure they are adequately cared for. This includes ensuring private rental homes and social housing for those with companion animals are readily available. Companion animals are more often than not considered an integral part of the family unit, with research demonstrating numerous benefits of companion animal guardianship.[48] At the same time, they rely on us to meet their needs.

In Aotearoa New Zealand, the high cost of purchasing housing has led to an increasing number of people turning to the private rental market for their accommodation needs. The median house price in Aotearoa has risen significantly over the past decade[49], making homeownership increasingly unattainable for many. This, coupled with factors such as student loan debt, changing job markets, lifestyle preferences, climate crisis impacts and immigration[50], has contributed to a growing renter population. According to recent statistics, approximately one-third of Aotearoa households are living in rental accommodation.[51] This translates to over 600,000 households, representing a significant portion of the population who are directly affected by rental policies and regulations.

The rental market has become a crucial component of Aotearoa's housing landscape, highlighting the importance of creating fair and inclusive policies that consider the needs of both tenants and landlords. The right to live with companion

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[47] Companion Animals New Zealand (2020). *Companion Animals in New Zealand* https://static1.squarespace.com/static/5d1bf13a3f8e880001289eeb/t/5f768e8a17377653bd1eebef/1601605338749/Companion+Animals+in+NZ+2020+%281%29.pdf

[48] McCarthy,L. & Simcock,T. (2024): Pets and private renting: a rapid evidence review of the barriers, benefits, and challenges, *International Journal of Housing Policy*, https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/pdf/10.1080/19491247.2024.2308711

[49] Edmunds, S. (2024, 13 February). House prices double in 10 years - but can it continue? *Stuff* https://www.stuff.co.nz/money/350176470/house-prices-double-10-years-can-it-continue

[50] Radio New Zealand (2023, 11 September). *Rapid growth in number of people looking for rentals in the last six months.* https://www.rnz.co.nz/news/national/497751/rapid-growth-in-number-of-people-looking-for-rentals-in-last-six-months

[51] New Zealand Stats (2019). *Renting vs owning in NZ*. https://www.stats.govt.nz/infographics/renting-vs-owning-in-nz

animals ranks highly among tenants' demands for policy change in the private rental sector.[52]

Benefits of living with companion animals

The ability to live with companion animals is increasingly considered a critical factor in tenants' capacity to establish a sense of home in rental properties.[53] Companion animals provide significant health benefits[54] to their guardians and help foster social interactions and promote a sense of neighbourliness[55]. For example, companion animals can have a positive impact on autistic owners, alleviating feelings of loneliness and helping to integrate them into the community.[56]

There are also physical health benefits as companion animal guardianship is associated with reduced minor health problems and increased physical exercise[57]. By creating barriers to companion animal ownership in private rental properties and social housing, the Government may be inadvertently contributing to poorer health outcomes for tenants, particularly those who are already vulnerable, and also creating a negative impact on community cohesion.

Animals are surrendered due to the lack of companion animal-friendly rentals

Allowing tenants to have companion animals in private rental properties and social housing can reduce the strain on animal rescues. These organisations are often overrun by surrendered and abandoned animals, partly due to housing restrictions forcing guardians to give up their beloved companion animals.

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[52] McCarthy,L. & Simcock,T. (2024): Pets and private renting:
a rapid evidence review of the barriers, benefits, and challenges, *International Journal of Housing Policy*, https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/pdf/10.1080/19491247.2024.2308711

[53] McCarthy,L. & Simcock,T. (2024): Pets and private renting:
a rapid evidence review of the barriers, benefits, and challenges. *International Journal of Housing Policy*, https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/pdf/10.1080/19491247.2024.2308711

[54] Bee, P. et al. (2018): The power of support from companion animals for people living with mental health problems: a systematic review and narrative synthesis of the evidence. *BMC Psychiatry Vol 18, 31.* https://link.springer.com/article/10.1186/s12888-018-1613-2

[55] Bennet, C. et al. (2018): 'More people talk to you when you have a dog' - Dogs as catalysts for social inclusion of people with intellectual disabilities. *Journal of intellectual disability research, Vol 62, 10.* https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/full/10.1111/jir.12538

[56] McCarthy,L. & Simcock,T. (2024): Pets and private renting:
a rapid evidence review of the barriers, benefits, and challenges, *International Journal of Housing Policy*, https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/pdf/10.1080/19491247.2024.2308711

[57] Allen, K. et al. (2013): Pet ownership and cardiovascular risk: A scientific statement from the American heart association. *Circulation Vol 127, 23.*
https://www.ahajournals.org/doi/full/10.1161/CIR.0b013e31829201e1

This situation is detrimental to both humans and animals. Companion animal guardians can face stress and mental health challenges when separated from their animal family members, but have no alternative but to surrender them to avoid homelessness.[58] The animals themselves also experience the trauma of separation and may face euthanasia due to overcrowded shelters. For example, In 2022-2023, the Royal New Zealand Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Incorporated (SPCA) in New Zealand took in 33,075 animals, but only 16,307[59] were subsequently adopted.

While rental restrictions are not the sole cause of animal surrenders, permitting desexed companion animals to live with their guardians in rental properties would help address this issue. It would enable more tenants to keep their companion animals, foster animals in need, and potentially adopt from shelters, thereby reducing the number of animals in rescue facilities and improving health and social outcomes for both people and companion animals.

Pet bonds create unfair barriers to housing access

Whilst the Residential Tenancies Amendment Bill 2024 provides that a landlord must have reasonable grounds to prohibit or refuse consent for a tenant to keep a pet, it introduces the concept of 'pet bonds'. A landlord may require payment of a bond to keep a pet in the rental property of up to 2 weeks' rent.[60] The Bill will come into force on a date, or dates, set by Order in Council, or a deferred commencement date of within 2 years from Royal Assent at the latest. It has been proposed that the commencement of the pet provisions should remain by Order in Council because the process for administering pet bonds will need to be developed.

In a fair and inclusive society, access to safe and affordable housing should be considered a basic right. Adding financial barriers based on companion animal guardianship contradicts this principle and creates a two-tiered system of housing access.

Requiring a 'pet bond' can create unfair barriers to housing access, placing an additional financial burden on tenants, which can be particularly challenging for those with limited income or other vulnerable populations, such as people escaping

[58] Fleury, J (2021, May 4). Families face 'heartbreaking decision' to rehome pets over rental rules. *NewsHub* https://www.newshub.co.nz/home/new-zealand/2021/05/spca-lack-of-pet-friendly-rentals-one-of-most-common-reasons-animals-are-surrendered-to-shelters.html

[59] The SPCA (Royal New Zealand Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Incorporated) https://www.spca.nz/about/reporting-back

[60] Residential Tenancies Amendment Bill 2024, Section 18AA. *Pet Bonds* https://www.legislation.govt.nz/bill/government/2024/0045/latest/whole.html#LMS960526

domestic violence, who often need to quickly find safe housing for themselves, their children, and their companion animals. An additional ‘pet bond’ can be an insurmountable obstacle in these crisis situations, forcing 53% of victims to delay leaving these situations as they have to choose[61] between their safety and their companion animals.

Lower income individuals and families are disproportionately discriminated against, making it harder for them to find suitable housing while keeping their beloved companion animals. Renting with a companion animal will only be possible for those with more disposable income, and this will continue to be exacerbated through inflation increases.[62]

By creating additional financial barriers, ‘pet bonds’ contribute to the perpetuation of housing inequality. This practice can lead to the concentration of companion animal friendly housing in more affluent areas, further marginalising lower income companion animal guardians.

The ‘pet bond’ also creates an unfair double standard as landlords already collect a general security deposit to cover potential damages. Requiring an additional ‘pet bond’ suggests that companion animal guardians are inherently more likely to cause damage, which unfairly penalises responsible companion animal guardians. Furthermore, it also opens up the potential for exploitation as the ‘pet bond’ system could be abused by unscrupulous landlords as a way to extract more money from tenants, regardless of the actual risk or potential damage associated with companion animals.

Higher upfront costs for companion animal guardians may also discourage people from adopting companion animals from shelters, potentially leading to higher euthanasia rates and overcrowded animal shelters.

Necessary legislation and insurance updates

It is important to note that current legislation does not adequately protect either landlords or tenants in situations involving companion animals. Animals are defined as ‘goods’ in the Residential Tenancies Act 1986[63], rather than individuals, with no

[61] Jury, A., Thorburn, N., & Burry, Kate. Pet Abuse as part of Intimate Partner Violence *Women's Refuge.* https://www.petrefuge.org.nz/media/soajptia/2018-womens-refuge-research1.pdf
[62] New Zealand Stats (2024, February 1) *Household living costs increase 7.0 percent* https://www.stats.govt.nz/news/household-living-costs-increase-7-0-percent/
[63] Residential Tenancies Act 1986 https://legislation.govt.nz/act/public/1986/0120/latest/whole.html?search=sw_096be8ed81d2fc65_chattels_25_se&p=1#DLM94283

specific provisions specifying the rights and responsibilities of companion animal guardians. Section 66k of the Act does, however, specify that tenants are not to keep a pet in a boarding house without the landlord's permission.

Recent Tenancy Tribunal decisions have indicated that, depending on the circumstances of the tenancy, including the type of pet, landlords may not be able to enforce a condition in a tenancy agreement that bans pets.

This lack of legal protection must be addressed for both parties to ensure that their respective rights and obligations are clear and enforceable.

AJP proposes legislative changes that will give tenants the legal protection to ensure that they can live in their rental home with their companion animals, free from discrimination and penalty. Moreover, we will advocate for legal protection to prevent landlords enforcing prohibitions such as breed specific restrictions, recognising that breed does not determine a dog's behaviour nor suitability as a companion animal, or tenants having a council bylaw specified maximum number of desexed dogs. We do, however, acknowledge the need for legislative provisions to prevent animal hoarding.

We aim to ensure landlords and tenants are adequately protected against potential damage caused by companion animals. It is vital to ensure that landlords have access to comprehensive coverage without penalising their decision to allow companion animals to live in their rental properties

We propose exploring and collaborating with insurance providers to create options specifically tailored to companion animal friendly rentals, encouraging the re-evaluation of policies that discriminate against landlords who allow tenants to live with companion animals. By offering these financial safeguards, concerns about property damage can be alleviated and more landlords can be encouraged to open their properties to companion animal owners.

Implementing education initiatives and companion animal CVs

Instead of 'pet bonds', other measures such as references from previous landlords, or companion animal CVs, could be used to assess responsible companion animal guardianship without creating financial barriers. Companion animals that are desexed, microchipped and registered will allow landlords to be more assured of the companion animal guardians' commitment to the welfare of the animals and compliance with legal requirements.

To foster a harmonious relationship between landlords and tenants with companion animals, it is essential to implement comprehensive measures that address the concerns of all parties involved and highlight the benefits of the relationship.

AJP proposes the development of educational campaigns in collaboration with relevant stakeholders to promote responsible companion animal ownership and property care. These initiatives will equip tenants with the knowledge and skills necessary to care for their animals, such as shelter needs, behavioural needs, and appropriate property care and respect for rental properties. The initiatives will also help landlords better understand the benefits and practicalities of allowing companion animals to live in their rentals with their guardians.

In addition to education, we recommend the establishment of a certification programme, to provide a "Seal of Approval" inspired by the SPCA CV[64]. This programme would entail a vetting process to assess the responsibility and reliability of companion animal guardians. Certified tenants could present their endorsement to potential landlords, thus providing assurance of their commitment to responsible companion animal ownership. The certification process would involve verification of companion animal documentation, including desexing certificates, microchip registration, vaccination records, and the companion animal's history with the owner.

Benefits for landlords

Allowing companion animals in rental properties can be financially beneficial for landlords. According to a study by FIREPAW, Inc., companion animals friendly rentals can increase profitability for property owners.[65] The study found that companion animals friendly units rented faster, had longer tenant stays, and experienced less tenant turnover.

On average,the study found that companion animal friendly properties remained occupied for 46 months compared to 18 months for rentals prohibiting companion animals. Additionally, the cost of damage from housing companion animals was found to be lower than the security deposits, resulting in a net financial benefit. These findings suggest that allowing companion animals can lead to increased rental income, reduced vacancy rates, and lower turnover costs, making it a potentially profitable decision for landlords.

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[64] SPCA (2024, June 17). how to write a pet CV when renting. https://www.spcapetinsurance.co.nz/pet-insurance/the-good-life/pet-cv-renting

[65] Best Friends (n.d.). *Pet-Friendly Rentals Increase Profitability for Landlords* https://bestfriends.org/pet-care-resources/pet-friendly-rentals-increase-profitability-landlords

Protecting tenants and landlords alike

To empower both tenants and landlords, it is vital to ensure that all parties are aware of their rights and responsibilities before entering into rental agreements. The current situation, where landlords typically have the right to deny renters the ability to have companion animals, is a significant concern that needs to be addressed. We propose developing clear processes for landlords to follow if they feel tenants are not acting responsibly in regards to companion animals guardianship. These will provide additional safeguards for landlords while giving tenants the opportunity to demonstrate their commitment to responsible companion animal guardianship.

Tenants should be made fully aware of the consequences should they fail to adhere to the requirements of their formal tenancy agreement relating to the ownership of companion animals. These requirements could include ensuring companion animals are desexed, microchipped, registered, and provided with adequate care to meet their behavioural and welfare needs. By establishing these clear requirements and expectations, landlords will be more empowered, while tenants will have the opportunity to prove their commitment to responsible companion animal guardianship.

Providing tenants with legal rights regarding animal guardianship will foster healthier tenant-landlord relationships. Tenants will feel more secure in their homes, knowing they are not at constant risk of losing housing stability, if they conduct themselves in a responsible manner and in accordance with the terms of the tenancy agreement. This approach will not only help reduce the number of animals surrendered to shelters due to housing restrictions but also foster a more inclusive and companion animal friendly rental market.

Initiatives for increasing companion animal friendly housing

It is vital to ensure there is support for animal friendly rental housing initiatives. By encouraging the development and ingenuity of these initiatives we can ensure there are enough rental houses for companion animal guardians, while assisting the societal shift needed to normalise animal friendly rental housing.

Initiatives such as Resido[66], a pet-friendly apartment complex in Sylvia Park, showcases the benefits of allowing tenants and landlords to open their homes to companion animals. This is a pivotal turning point in shifting societal and legislative change to allow tenants to enjoy a life with their furry friends.

[66] https://thespinoff.co.nz/partner/03-07-2024/renting-in-auckland-sucks-but-it-doesnt-have-to

Facilitating greater choices for tenants with companion animals, including tenants in intensive housing and animal friendly rest homes, means there will be more opportunities for investors, landlords and tenants alike to enjoy the benefits of companion animal guardianship.

Universal Veterinary Care - Ensuring Wellbeing for All Animals

The AJP is committed to establishing veterinary care as a fundamental right for all animals, recognising that access to medical treatment should never depend on their guardian's wealth or their status as companion, free-living, or wildlife. We acknowledge that the current system fails countless animals who suffer needlessly due to financial barriers, geographic inequities, and a veterinary workforce pushed to breaking point by commercial pressures and inadequate support. We propose comprehensive reforms to create a universal veterinary care system that prioritises animal wellbeing over profit, ensuring no animal is denied treatment because of economic circumstances.

The veterinary care crisis in Aotearoa reflects broader societal failures to value animal lives equally. Countless companion animals live in households struggling with the cost of living, where a sudden illness or injury forces impossible choices between veterinary bills and basic necessities. Meanwhile, injured wildlife, including our precious native species, suffer without treatment, and free-living cats and dogs continue breeding due to lack of accessible desexing services, perpetuating cycles of suffering that overwhelm rescue organisations and community groups.

This crisis is not inevitable, it is a direct consequence of treating veterinary medicine as a luxury commodity rather than essential care. The current system concentrates services in wealthy urban areas while rural and regional communities face severe shortages, leaving both animals and their human carers without local access to critical treatment. Veterinarians themselves suffer under this model, with crushing student debt, unsustainable workloads, and moral injury from having to deny care based on payment capacity driving concerning rates of burnout and mental health struggles within the profession.

The economic barriers are deliberately constructed. GST on veterinary services treats animal healthcare as discretionary spending, while limited university places and high fees create artificial scarcity that drives up costs and restricts workforce growth. Emergency procedures can cost thousands of dollars, forcing people to choose between insurmountable debt or euthanasia, while preventative care like

desexing remains financially out of reach for many households, particularly in communities already facing economic hardship.

The connection to animal justice is fundamental and inseparable. Every animal who dies from a treatable condition because their carer couldn't afford treatment represents a failure of our society's values. Every injured kererū, kākā, or kiwi who suffers without veterinary intervention because there's no guaranteed funding for wildlife care reveals the hollowness of our claimed concern for biodiversity and our taonga species. Every free-living cat or dog who continues breeding because desexing is unaffordable perpetuates suffering across generations and threatens our native wildlife.

This policy also addresses the exploitation of veterinary professionals themselves. The current system transforms dedicated animal carers into gatekeepers of treatment based on payment, creating profound moral distress that drives people from the profession. By removing financial barriers and adequately resourcing veterinary services, we create conditions where practitioners can focus on healing rather than billing, reducing the psychological harm that comes from denying necessary care to animals in their most vulnerable moments.

Beyond individual animals, lack of accessible veterinary care undermines community resilience and ecological health. Undesexed companion animal populations strain rescue networks, SPCA resources, and council pounds. Untreated injuries in free-living animals can lead to infection and disease spread that affects both domestic and native species. The absence of preventative care creates more expensive emergency interventions that people still cannot afford, perpetuating cycles of suffering, guilt, and animal abandonment.

The current model also perpetuates inequality between communities. Whānau in rural areas, small towns, and lower-income urban neighbourhoods face the greatest barriers, paying more to travel further for care that may not even be available locally. This geographic and economic discrimination means that where an animal lives determines whether they receive treatment, fundamentally contradicting any meaningful commitment to animal welfare.

The AJP believes that establishing universal veterinary care is an essential foundation for a compassionate society. It will save countless animals from preventable suffering, support carers in providing responsible care regardless of income or location, and create a veterinary profession where practitioners can fulfil their calling without the moral injury of profit-driven gatekeeping. This is not charity, it is recognition that animals' right to medical care should not depend on economic circumstance or postcode.

Key Objectives:

1. Establish Veticare—a universal veterinary care scheme providing government-funded treatment for all companion animals, with priority access for low-income households, superannuitants, and animal rescue workers
2. Remove GST from all veterinary services immediately, recognising animal healthcare as essential rather than discretionary spending
3. Create a national network of publicly funded veterinary clinics in underserved areas, with mobile services ensuring no animal is denied care due to geography
4. Fund comprehensive desexing programs for all companion and free-living cats and dogs to prevent suffering and protect native wildlife from predation
5. Establish dedicated wildlife veterinary services with guaranteed public funding for treatment of injured native and other animals
6. Transform veterinary education and workforce conditions by reducing financial barriers to training, improving mental health support, and providing incentives for practitioners in areas of greatest need
7. Deploy local animal ambulance services in every region for rapid transport of injured wildlife and vulnerable animals to critical care
8. Create a publicly accessible national register of financial support schemes, subsidised services, and payment options in te reo Māori and community languages
9. Implement strong regulations against price exploitation by corporate veterinary chains to protect independent practices and affordable community care
10. Establish community oversight through local animal welfare councils with power to direct resources to areas of greatest need and ensure meaningful representation from Māori, Pasifika and diverse communities

4. Protection and Advocacy Rights

Comprehensive Whistleblower Protection and Peaceful Protest Rights

The AJP is committed to protecting the fundamental democratic rights of transparency, accountability, and peaceful protest that are essential for exposing and addressing animal cruelty. We acknowledge that industries profiting from animal exploitation are increasingly using legal strategies, such as ag-gag laws, to silence critics, hide their practices from public scrutiny, and criminalise those who seek to document or protest against animal abuse. We propose comprehensive protections for whistleblowers and peaceful protesters to ensure that the voices of animals and their advocates cannot be silenced.

Ag-gag laws are anti-whistleblower laws that forbid undercover filming or photography of activity on farms without consent, specifically targeting whistleblowers of suspected animal rights abuses. These dangerous bills, pushed by the animal agriculture industry, are designed to silence whistleblowers revealing animal abuses on industrial farms.

Since 2011, twenty-five US states have introduced ag-gag laws, with six passing legislation that falls into three categories: agricultural interference laws (prohibiting recording without consent), agricultural fraud laws (prohibiting obtaining access under false pretences), and agricultural terrorism laws.[67]

The threat extends beyond the US. In Australia, ag-gag laws seek to hinder animal advocates by preventing them from recording operations of commercial agricultural facilities. Meanwhile, both NSW and Queensland governments, as well as the Australian federal government, are ramping up laws against animal activists who trespass on farming properties.[68]

The assault on democratic rights extends to peaceful protest. Five Australian states (NSW, Queensland, South Australia, Tasmania and Victoria) have introduced anti-protest regulations, with South Australia's new laws increasing maximum fines from $750 to $50,000 along with potential jail time. [69] The former Australian

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[67] Animal Legal Defense Fund (n.d). Tracking ag-gag laws in the United States. Animal Legal Defense Fund. Retrieved October 24, 2025, from https://aldf.org/issue/ag-gag/

[68] Buxton, A. (2023, May 4). *Australia's new farm trespass law a 'smokescreen' to criminalize animal activists* Plant Based News. https://plantbasednews.org/culture/law-and-politics/australia-farm-trespass-law-activists/

[69] Australian Broadcasting Corporation (ABC). (2023, May 19). *Unions and human rights groups slam SA protest law change rushed through parliament*. ABC News.

government introduced the Charities Amendment (Strengthening the Integrity of Civil Society) Bill 2021 (Cth), which sought to give the Australian Charities and Not-for-profits Commission (ACNC) broader powers to deregister a charity for minor offences related to protest.[70] However, following strong backlash from charitable and human rights organizations who argued the changes would stifle legitimate advocacy, the government ultimately decided not to proceed with the bill.

Human Rights Watch found that authorities in NSW are disproportionately punishing climate protesters in violation of their basic rights to peaceful protest,[71] while Article 21 of the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights recognises the right to peaceful assembly, which Australia has ratified.[72]

Undercover investigations by animal advocates are a critical tool in exposing the cruel realities of factory farming, yet instead of protecting animals, industrial agriculture continues introducing anti-whistleblower legislation. This creates a dangerous precedent where industries can hide systematic abuse behind legal barriers, preventing the public from making informed choices about animal welfare.

The AJP believes that protecting whistleblowers and peaceful protesters is a fundamental step that can be taken now to maintain democratic accountability and transparency. It will ensure that animal cruelty cannot be hidden behind legal barriers, enable informed public discourse about animal welfare, and preserve the essential democratic rights that allow society to progress towards greater compassion for all beings. Without these protections, industries that profit from animal exploitation can operate in secrecy, perpetuating suffering while silencing those who advocate for the voiceless.

Key Objectives:

1. Establish comprehensive legal protections for whistleblowers exposing animal cruelty, environmental violations, or public health risks in animal agriculture
2. Strengthen penalties for retaliation against employees, journalists, or advocates who expose animal abuse
3. Protect the fundamental right to peaceful protest and prevent criminalisation of non-violent advocacy for animals

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https://www.abc.net.au/news/2023-05-19/unions-and-human-rights-groups-slam-sa-protest-law-change/102367076

[70] Parliament of Australia. (2021). Charities Amendment (Strengthening the Integrity of Civil Society) Bill 2021 (Cth).

[71] McNeill, S. (2023, May 30). *Australia's crackdown on climate activists*. Human Rights Watch. https://www.hrw.org/news/2023/05/30/australias-crackdown-climate-activists

[72] International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights, G.A. Res. 2200A (XXI), 21 U.N. GAOR Supp. (No. 16) at 52, U.N. Doc. A/6316 (1966) (entered into force Mar. 23, 1976). https://doi.org/10.1093/rsq/hdi031

4. Create legal pathways for transparency in animal agriculture while respecting legitimate privacy and security concerns

Breaking the Cycle - Pet Refuge Support for Domestic Violence Survivors

The AJP is committed to eliminating barriers that prevent people from escaping domestic violence, recognising that the safety of beloved companion animals is often the deciding factor that keeps victims trapped in dangerous situations. We acknowledge that New Zealand has the highest rate of domestic violence among OECD countries,[73] combined with one of the highest rates of pet ownership globally,[74] yet we have only one pet refuge service operating in Auckland.[75] We propose establishing a nationwide network of pet refuge facilities to ensure no family stays in danger because they cannot safely care for their animals.

Cruelty to animals is common in domestic violence situations, where people who use violence will often threaten, injure and even kill a pet to control family members. Research consistently shows that abusers use pets as weapons of emotional manipulation, knowing that their victims' love for animals creates a powerful tool for control.[76]

New research from Women's Refuge reveals a huge number of women delay leaving abusive relationships because they fear what will happen to their pets.[77] This barrier is particularly significant given that it's estimated one third of people in New Zealand have experienced intimate partner violence within their lifetime.

Currently, Pet Refuge New Zealand - located only in Auckland - provides the country's first and only shelter dedicated to housing pets affected by family violence

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[73] Pet Refuge. (n.d.). *Domestic violence & pet abuse*. Retrieved October 24, 2025, from https://www.petrefuge.org.nz/domestic-violence-pet-abuse/
[74] Companion Animals New Zealand. (2024). *2024 NZ Pet Data Report*. https://www.companionanimals.nz/2024-nz-pet-data-report
[75] Pet Refuge New Zealand Charitable Trust. (n.d.). *Home* [Website]. Retrieved October 24, 2025, from https://www.petrefuge.org.nz/
[76] Cleary, C., O'Halloran, K., Naughton, C., & Cleary, A. (2021). Animal abuse in the context of adult intimate partner violence: A systematic review. Nursing, *Paramedicine and Healthcare Sciences.* https://researchoutput.csu.edu.au/en/publications/animal-abuse-in-the-context-of-adult-intimate-partner-violence-a-/
[77] Chhour, K. (2025, June 4). *Protecting Families by Protecting Pets – a national call to action* [Press release]. New Zealand Government. https://www.beehive.govt.nz/release/protecting-families-protecting-pets-%E2%80%93-national-call-action

while their owners escape abuse. Pet Refuge helps all kinds of pets from cats, dogs, birds, rabbits, horses and reptiles at no cost to families escaping abuse.

However, domestic violence doesn't discriminate between regions, and families outside Auckland face impossible choices between their safety and their animals' wellbeing. The founder notes that "when we've got a pet coming in, we know that means a family has been able to leave abuse"[78] - highlighting how crucial these services are for enabling escape from violence.

The AJP believes that establishing comprehensive pet refuge services is a crucial step that can be taken now to remove barriers preventing families from escaping violence. It will enable more people to leave dangerous situations without abandoning beloved animals, reduce the trauma experienced by both humans and animals in violent households, and create a safety net that recognises the profound bonds between people and their companion animals as legitimate and worthy of protection.

Key Objectives:

1. Establish a nationwide network of pet refuge facilities ensuring every region has accessible, safe temporary housing for companion animals affected by domestic violence
2. Provide comprehensive support services including veterinary care, behavioural rehabilitation, and trauma recovery for animals who have experienced abuse
3. Create integrated referral systems connecting domestic violence services with pet refuge facilities to streamline support for families
4. Fund ongoing operations to ensure pet refuge services remain free for families escaping violence, removing financial barriers to safety
5. Establish a 24/7 emergency hotline for immediate pet refuge placement needs and rapid response protocols for situations where pets are in immediate danger
6. Develop and implement a comprehensive animal trauma rehabilitation programme that includes specialized behavioral therapy for abused animals, staff training in trauma recognition, and integrated therapeutic interventions that support the healing of both human survivors and their companion animals.
7. Advocacy for stronger legal penalties for those who threaten or harm animals as tools of domestic control

[78] Seah, N.. (2022, March 29). *The hidden victims of family violence*. The Spinoff. https://thespinoff.co.nz/society/29-03-2022/the-hidden-victims-of-family-violence-2

5. Education and Community Building

Compassionate Education - Building Empathy Through Learning

The AJP is committed to transforming education to nurture empathy, ethical awareness and respect for all living beings from early childhood through to tertiary study. We acknowledge that traditional education often fails to develop students' capacity for compassion towards animals, may actively desensitise them to animal suffering through harmful practices like dissection, and often produces graduates who perpetuate systems of animal exploitation. We propose comprehensive reforms to embed compassionate principles throughout New Zealand's education system.

Recognising and treating animals as sentient beings by providing them with a good life with opportunities for positive experiences is essential for the development of empathy. Developing empathy (particularly for animals) is an important foundation for creating an ethical, compassionate, and humane society. Given the correlation between human violence and animal cruelty,[79] the SPCA recognises that inspiring a kinder generation through animal welfare education will not only improve the world for animals but for humans as well.[80]

SPCA's education strategy is based on evidence from international research in the field of animal welfare education. This research highlights that the most effective time to provide education of this type is between 7 and 12 years of age. Advocating for humane education to become an integral part of each child's formal education is fundamental to the long-term strategy of alleviating animal suffering on a grand scale.[81]

While specific statistics for New Zealand are not readily available, international data shows the scale of animal use in education remains substantial - more than 12 million animals, including frogs, cats, rats, fetal pigs, fish and a variety of invertebrates are used for dissection in the US each year.[82] In New Zealand, around 300,000 animals are used for research, testing and teaching annually, though this

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[79] Robinson, C. & Clausen, V. (2021). The link between animal cruelty and human violence. FBI Law Enforcement Bulletin. https://leb.fbi.gov/articles/featured-articles/the-link-between-animal-cruelty-and-human-violence

[80] SPCA New Zealand. (n.d.). *Animal welfare education*. https://www.spca.nz/advocacy/position-statements/article/animal-welfare-education

[81] ibid

[82] PETA. (n.d.). *Animals used in education*. Retrieved October 24, 2025, from https://www.peta.org/issues/animals-used-for-experimentation/classroom-dissection/

includes university-level research and teaching beyond school dissection programmes.[83]

NZAVS identifies that animals are sadly still used in harmful ways for teaching purposes in New Zealand schools and universities, where "animals are forced to undergo something that is likely to cause them pain, injury, distress, or death, and that is not meant to benefit that specific animal involved."[84] Meanwhile, students today have cleaner, safer, and more advanced models for biological discovery than ever before.

Primary and Secondary Education Reform:

Compassionate Curriculum Integration:

- Mandatory humane education modules integrated across subjects including science, social studies, literature, and citizenship
- Age-appropriate lessons on animal sentience, behaviour, and welfare needs
- Critical thinking components examining the ethics of human-animal relationships
- Environmental education emphasising the interconnectedness of human, animal, and planetary wellbeing

Compassionate Management of Introduced Species:

- Educational programmes teaching non-lethal, humane approaches to biodiversity challenges
- Emphasis on ecosystem-based management solutions that consider animal welfare
- Teaching about the complex relationships between endemic and introduced animals
- Rejection of divisive language promoting killing and trapping as conservation tools

Elimination of Harmful Animal Use:

- Complete phase-out of animal dissection in favour of superior alternatives
- Implementation of student choice laws allowing students the right to refuse to participate in classroom exercises that harm animals

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[83] Ministry for Primary Industries. (2024). *Statistics on the use of animals in research, testing and teaching in New Zealand in 2023*. New Zealand Government https://www.mpi.govt.nz/animals/animal-welfare/animals-research-testing-teaching/statistics-on-the-use-of-animals-in-research-testing-and-teaching

[84] New Zealand Anti-Vivisection Society. (n.d.). *Ending animal dissections in NZ schools*. Retrieved October 24, 2025, from https://www.nzavs.org.nz/our-work/kind-education

- Replacement of classroom pets and live animal demonstrations with observation-based learning at sanctuaries and education centres
- Prohibition on projects requiring students to exploit animals or animal products

Modern Teaching Alternatives:

- Investment in humane, effective, animal-free teaching tools including virtual reality, digital dissection, and anatomical models
- Access to free dissection alternatives loan programmes and virtual anatomy resources
- Training for teachers in using advanced, animal-free educational technologies
- Development of New Zealand-specific resources featuring native wildlife and ecosystems

Tertiary Education Transformation:

Animal Science Programme Reform:

- Mandatory courses on animal sentience, cognition, and welfare science for all animal science students
- Ethics components examining the moral implications of different animal use practices
- Emphasis on animal-free research, teaching and testing methods and plant-based alternatives to animal agriculture
- Career pathway support for students interested in companion animal care, wildlife rehabilitation, and plant-based food systems

Professional Development Requirements:

- Continuing education requirements for teachers on compassionate education methods
- Training programmes for educators on recognising and addressing speciesism in curricula
- Support for teachers to develop animal-friendly lesson plans that avoid treating animals as disposable commodities. Eg. https://www.faunedge.com/

Research and Graduate Studies:

- Funding prioritisation for research into animal-free education methods
- Graduate programmes focusing on animal welfare, conservation biology, and sustainable food systems
- Legislated ethical review requirements for any research involving animals, with animal testing only to be used as a last resort where non-animal methods are not available

Specialised Education Centres:

Animal Welfare Education Hubs:

- Establishment of dedicated centres teaching about animal behaviour, cognition, and welfare without using live animals
- Interactive exhibits using technology, models, and observation of animals in natural settings
- Programmes for school groups, families, and community organizations
- Training facilities for educators in compassionate teaching methods

Wildlife Education Sanctuaries:

- Support for existing wildlife sanctuaries to develop educational programming
- Observation-based learning about native species behaviour and conservation
- Teaching about ecosystem relationships and the impacts of human activities on wildlife
- Programmes specifically addressing compassionate approaches to introduced species management

Community Education:

Public Awareness Campaigns:

- Community programmes teaching responsible companion animal guardianship
- Public education about the welfare needs of farmed animals and plant-based alternatives to animal agriculture
- Workshops on compassionate approaches to wildlife conflicts
- Integration of animal welfare education into adult education and community college programmes

Professional Training:

- Mandatory animal welfare training for professionals working with animals
- Continuing education requirements for veterinarians, farmers, and animal care workers
- Public education campaigns about career opportunities in plant-based food production and animal welfare

Teacher Support and Resources:

Curriculum Development:

- Development of comprehensive, age-appropriate compassionate education resources
- Translation of international humane education materials for Aotearoa New Zealand context
- Integration with existing curriculum requirements to avoid teacher burden
- Regular review and updating of materials based on current animal welfare science

Professional Support:

- Protected time for teachers to participate in compassionate education training
- Financial support for schools implementing animal-free teaching alternatives
- Networks connecting teachers using compassionate education approaches
- Recognition programmes for schools demonstrating excellence in humane education

The AJP believes that implementing compassionate education is a transformative step that can be taken now to build a generation of citizens who value and respect all living beings. It will create students equipped with the empathy and critical thinking skills necessary for addressing complex ethical challenges, reduce unnecessary animal suffering in educational settings, and establish the foundation for a society that extends compassion to all sentient beings while preparing young people for careers in a plant-based economy.

Key Objectives:

1. Implement mandatory compassionate education curricula across all educational levels that teach respect for animals, environmental stewardship, and ethical decision-making
2. Eliminate harmful animal use in educational settings by replacing dissection and animal experimentation with superior non-animal alternatives
3. Establish specialised education centres that teach animal behaviour and welfare without exploiting live animals
4. Transform animal science education to focus on compassionate management rather than exploitation of animals